

Devils' lights-out shooting is too much for Rangers

By BOB MIGRA
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Brunswick got on one of those rolls that coaches and players dream about last night.

After an ice-cold start, the Blue Devils shot 70 percent from the field in the final three quarters to defeat Lakewood in the Division I district tournament at Midview.

The 66-45 victory gave Brunswick its first district championship in boys basketball.

"I can't even explain this feeling," guard Mike Mixon said minutes after the Blue Devils turned into a team of human pogo sticks

BRUNSWICK 66
LAKEWOOD 45

while being mobbed by fans at center court. "This is the best time I've ever had in my life."

Mixon got the Blue Devils going after the team started with a 1-for-14 effort from the field in the first quarter.

Lakewood's Dan Crawford started the second quarter scoring with a layup off a give-and-go from Dan Budzar for a 13-2 lead.

Mixon countered with a 3-point goal, and suddenly, the shooting switch was turned on for the Blue Devils.

"I was a little nervous, but it was just the beginning of the game jitters," Mixon said. "Once

we got going, we caught fire for a minute."

It was more like 20 minutes.

Mixon came back with another 3-point goal on Brunswick's next possession. After a foul shot by Brian Heaver, Mark Herman swished two consecutive 3-point goals to give Brunswick its first lead, 15-13.

"We were just hoping to get it going," Herman said. "We've been struggling in the first quarter just about every game. When Mixon hits a shot like that, usually everybody will start hitting. We feed off Mixon."

Two foul shots and a foul-line jump shot by Heaver finished Brunswick's 17-0 run, good for a 19-13 lead.

Herman led Brunswick with 16

points. Heaver scored 15 and Mixon had 12.

"I give the kids a lot of credit," Brunswick coach Joe Mackey said. "They didn't lose their composure in the first quarter. I knew eventually they would catch fire."

Mackey said the Blue Devils shot the 3-pointer fairly well during the regular season, but they had been struggling in the tournament.

"We picked the right time to catch fire tonight," Mackey said.

The Blue Devils added to their lead with four more 3-point goals in the third quarter, three by Steve Marenoski, to take a 49-34 lead.

"I'm so happy for our kids," Mackey said. "One of our goals when I took this job three years

ago was to get a banner on the wall in the gym. We're really excited."

Brunswick (13-11) advances to the Toledo regional Wednesday.

Lakewood ends its season at 8-16. Despite the fact that neither team was seeded and both teams entered the tournament with sub-.500 records, neither coach would call his team a Cinderella team.

"Every coach dreams of peaking at the right time," Mackey said. "We're right where we wanted to be."

Lakewood coach Bob Patton said his team's record was more the result of a killer schedule than lack of skill.

"They can call them upsets, but I think we had as good a chance as any team playing here," Patton

said. "Our league is so outstanding. We could have three teams from [the Lake Erie League] in the regionals."

Patton said he credited Brunswick for playing a strong game offensively and defensively.

"They broke us down with their full-court pressure," Patton said. "That's been our nemesis all year. Once they starting hitting their shots, I never thought they were going to miss. To keep their poise and come back the way they did is a sign of a team that's maturing. I was really impressed."

Budzar, displaying a variety of nice moves around the basket, led the Rangers with 18 points. Rashad Roundtree came off the bench to score 12 points and pull down eight rebounds.

Bulldogs win OT thriller

Beat Pirates to advance to regionals

By JACK McDERMOTT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Forget bragging rights. It was an all-out war last night in the boys Division II district championship showdown at Admiral King between Southwestern Conference mates Olmsted Falls and Rocky River.

When the battle was over, Olmsted Falls (21-2) prevailed, 71-68, in overtime to advance

to a Division II regional semifinal in Bowling Green on Wednesday night at 8:15 against Columbus Beechcroft.

The teams played twice during the regular season, with the Pirates (18-6) winning the first encounter, 61-51, on the Bulldogs' floor. The Bulldogs returned the favor with a 55-48 win on River's floor.

OLMSTED FALLS 71
ROCKY RIVER 68

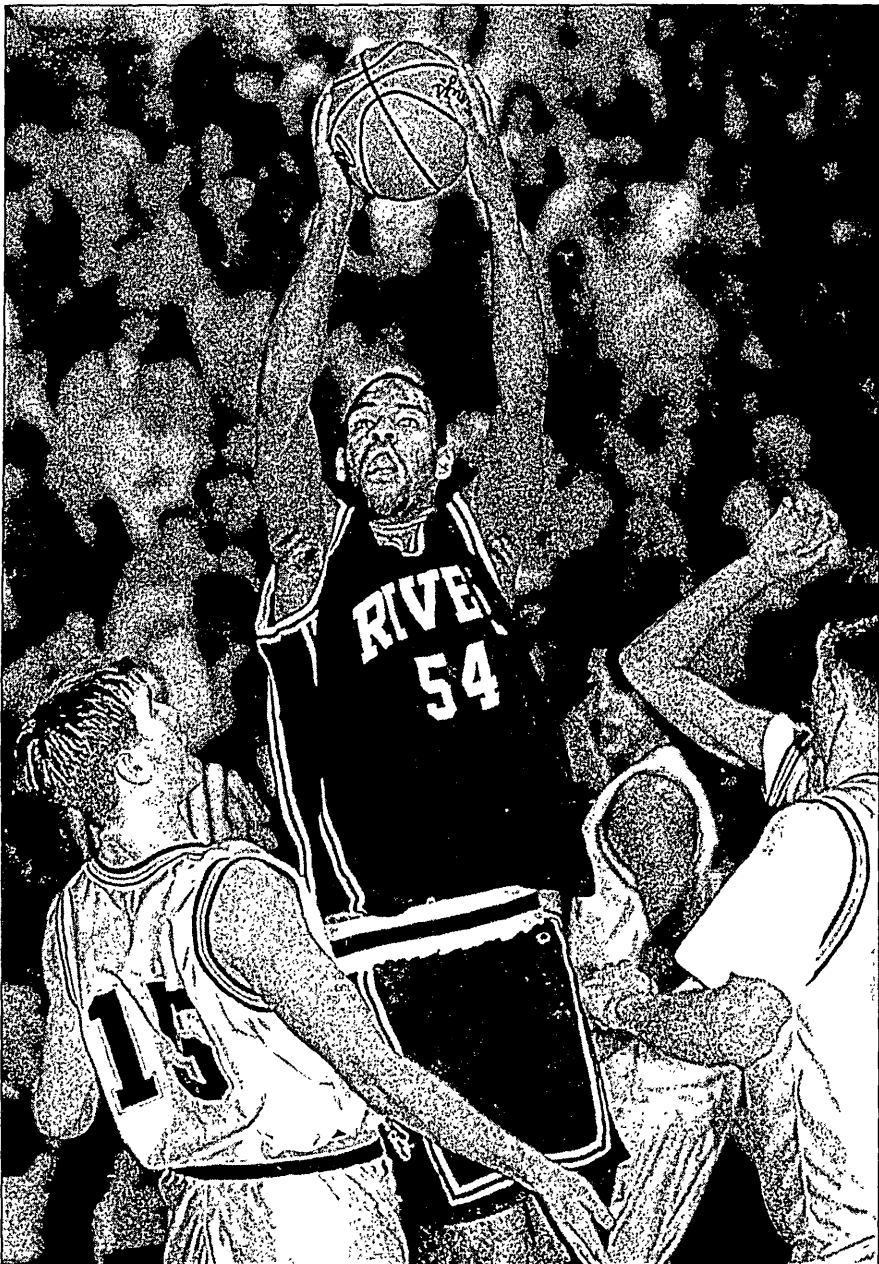
"This was very similar to the first two meetings," said Bulldogs coach Pat Donahue. "It was a see-saw game in which I never felt comfortable. This was the first close game we've had in a long time, and I'm very happy with the way my kids kept their composure."

The shot of the night in regulation play came with .8 seconds left as River's John Caruso sank a 3-pointer from the left sideline to send the game into overtime tied at 60.

The outcome was decided in the final 17 seconds of overtime, when Olmsted Falls sophomore Mike Gansey, a first-team all-district selection, made an 18-footer from the key to give the Bulldogs a 69-68 advantage, followed by two free throws, with 6.4 seconds left, by Bulldogs junior Larry Mucha.

"Our game plan coming in was to hopefully handle their pressure," said Rocky River coach Jim Rucki. "But, even if you beat their pressure, that doesn't necessarily mean you are going to be effective against them. They're just a very strong club, and they keep coming at you. There's no chance to rest against them. You've just got to keep licking your wounds and keep clawing away with them."

Olmsted Falls trailed, 12-10, with 4:12 remaining in the first period, after River's Mike Woodward scored from underneath. The Bulldogs went on an 8-0 run



SCOTT SHAW / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Rocky River's Dave Miller shoots among Olmsted Falls players, including Greg Koch, left. Olmsted Falls won the Division II district championship game, 71-68, in overtime last night at Admiral King.

to take an 18-12 lead with 2:39 left in the period on a basket by Gansey. From there, Falls moved ahead, 22-14, after baskets by junior Manzie Williams, only to have River's Jeff Peate connect on a 3-pointer from behind the key at the buzzer, cutting the Bulldogs' first-quarter advantage to 22-17.

Rocky River battled back, out-

scoring the Bulldogs, 12-8, in the second period, thanks, in part, to a nine-point effort by Woodward, to trail by a point, 30-29, at halftime. The two teams drew even, 44-44, after three quarters.

Williams led all scorers with 23 points, five in overtime. Gansey, who scored eight points in the first quarter, finished with 18, and Mucha had 10. Caruso led the Pirates with 22 points, and Wood-

ward and Peate finished with 14 each. Junior Dave Miller scored 13.

"Gansey's basket was the big one for us," Donahue said. "But, this was definitely a total team effort from beginning to end. We always seem to have someone ready to step up when we need them, and tonight was no different. It was one heck of an effort by our entire team."

Raiders sport a new feeling, rip Comets

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

During a recent English class, Shaker Heights senior forward Anton Smith wrote in his journal that he never again wanted to experience the feeling he had after the Raiders lost to Buchtel in last season's regional semifinals.

Yesterday, in front of a crowd of more than

2,000 at Cleveland South, Smith and his teammates took another step toward erasing that memory.

Shaker Heights, behind a relentless pressure defense and an offense that jelled in transition and in the half court, overwhelmed a talented Solon team, 75-32, in a Division I boys basketball district championship game.

The Raiders (22-1), who captured their second consecutive district title at South, advanced to Thursday night's regional semifinal against the Euclid district champion. The tipoff in the University of Akron's JAR Arena will be at 7 p.m.

"No, never, never do I want to have that feeling again," Smith

SHAKER HEIGHTS 75
SOLON 32

said, referring to the 63-57 loss to Buchtel, a defeat that saw Shaker Heights squander a nine-point halftime lead. "That is what pushes me every time out."

The Raiders, playing like a team on a mission, held a 16-8 lead late in the first quarter after senior guard Jon Higgins hit a jumper in transition. Solon, champion of the Western Reserve Conference, closed to 16-11 on a 3-pointer by senior forward Aron Weston.

But sparked by a one-handed slam dunk by senior center Michael Tucker, Shaker Heights went on a 13-0 run, and the Comets were reeling.

A follow by senior forward Sidney Williams, a layup by Smith off a steal and an assist by Tucker and a driving layup by Higgins pushed the Raiders' lead to 24-11 and had Solon coach Mike Guilfoyle calling for a timeout.

Following the timeout, Shaker Heights kept the heat on and capped the run with a putback by Tucker, a reverse layup along the baseline by Williams and a steal

and a free throw by senior guard Todd Finley.

"They are just an amazing team, especially at the defensive end," said Guilfoyle, who guided the Comets to a 19-4 record. "They just keep coming at you. Their trap really disrupted us. We couldn't penetrate or swing the ball inside like we like to, and that's a credit to them."

"But we have no shame. It's been a great year, and that's what I'm going to emphasize to the kids when I walk into that locker room."

After outscoring Solon, 7-2, in the final 3:50 of the first half, the Raiders led, 36-15. Tucker and Williams combined for 22 first-half points, with Tucker scoring 10 of his 14 points in the first eight minutes. Williams finished with a game-high 20 points, scoring 10 in each half.

"Coach [Bob] Wonson always stresses that defense is going to get it done," said Tucker, a first-team All-Northeast Lakes District selection. "The offense will eventually come. But defense is always going to be there for us."

In the third quarter, Shaker Heights, ranked second in the fi-

nal Associated Press big-school state poll, simply wore Solon down with its defensive pressure and depth. Two 3-pointers by reserve forward Kevin Foster helped the Raiders extend their advantage to 46-21 and, after Higgins buried a 3-pointer and Williams converted a breakaway into a slam dunk, Shaker Heights coasted into the fourth quarter with a 53-24 lead.

Eleven players saw action for the Raiders, with 10 of them scoring.

"I thought if we were able to accomplish three things we had a pretty good chance of winning this game," said Wonson, the big-school Coach of the Year in the Northeast Lakes District. "Number one, we had to stop transition. Solon is probably as good a transition team as we've seen all year. Number two, we had to defend penetration; and three, we had to make sure that we didn't give up many bonus points, which are second shots off the boards."

Wonson's Raiders did all three and more as, in the words of Smith, they were fueled by last year's disappointment and driven by their defense.

WOOSTER — Miquel Irvin had mixed feelings about this one.

"I'm happy with the win, but I'm not happy with the way we played," said the St. Vincent-St. Mary basketball player after last night's 42-35 win over Waynedale in the Division III district finals.

"At times, we let the crowd and the refs get into our heads," Irvin said. "Their fans were pretty loud. With the refs, I'm not saying they did a bad job. But as tight as they called the game, it didn't give us a chance to play."

Even so, the Irish (15-8) won't complain too much. Making it to regionals has put smiles on their faces.

"Hey, we survived," SVSM coach Keith Dambrot said. "We didn't get out early, and I knew if we didn't get out early, this was going to be tough."

The rim was unkind to both teams in the first quarter. Waynedale (15-8) opened the game with two free throws, and SVSM did not score until Maverick Carter (18 points) made a basket with 5:19 left in the period. That tied it, 2-2.

"We usually come out more composed than this," SVSM guard Chad Mraz said. "I think the crowd and the refs got to us."

With 53 seconds left in the quarter, SVSM caught a break when Waynedale picked up a technical foul.

"One of our players on the bench apparently said something to one of the refs," Waynedale coach Erich Riebe said. "That was upsetting. I thought I should be the one to pick up a technical. It's hard for me to stay seated, and after picking that up, I pretty

much had to stay seated the rest of the game."

The Irish, who made 15 of 40 shots, held an 8-6 lead after the first quarter.

"This is the worst we've shot in the tournament," Irvin said.

SVSM built a small lead early in the second quarter, taking a 14-8 advantage on Irvin's layup. But the Golden Bears answered, tying it, 14-14, with six seconds left in the half on a layup.

"I think we were a little tight early," Dambrot said. "This was like a road game for us."

By the end of the third quarter, SVSM had a little breathing room. Tied, 24-24, the Irish closed the quarter with two 3-pointers from Carter. The first one came from the right baseline with 1:25 left, and the second came from the left wing as time expired in the quarter.

The teams continued to play tight defense. SVSM took a 33-25 lead with 5:33 remaining in the game on a free throw from Carter.

"In the second half, we didn't do a good job of defensive rebounding," said Riebe, whose team equaled SVSM's 23 rebounds. "We were outsize. We went into this game knowing we'd have to win it with fundamentals."

"They're not only a good team, they're strong. We knew we had our hands full."

Waynedale cut the lead to 33-28 with five minutes left on a three-point play. SVSM answered with a running jumper from Carter. The Golden Bears came within 36-33, when Brett Arnette (20 points) sank a 3-pointer from the right wing with 2:15 remaining.

"Arnette is a tough player," Carter said. "They knew they had to get him the ball."

'Unsung heroes' lift Shaw to district title

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Jason Moore said he was playing for the late David Parker and representing the "Class of 2000."

Last night, Moore couldn't have played harder and couldn't have represented Shaw or the memory

of Parker in a more dramatic fashion.

The Red Ball Express, behind two free throws by Moore with

three seconds left, turned back Euclid, 75-73, in a Division I boys basketball district championship game at Euclid.

Shaw (19-4), which won its second consecutive district title, will face Shaker Heights (22-1) in a regional semifinal matchup Thursday night at 7 in the University of Akron's JAR Arena.

As they have done throughout the season, Moore and his teammates will dedicate Thursday's game to Parker, their former teammate who collapsed and died from a heart condition during last year's sectional tournament at Euclid.

"This just feels great," said Shaw coach Leon Hines as he secured the district championship trophy in his arms. "There were so many unsung heroes tonight, guys who made this all possible."

Shaw, co-champion with Bedford in the Lake Erie League Erie Division, rode 14 first-quarter points by Moore to a 20-7 lead after the first eight minutes. Moore finished with a game-high 27 points.

With All-District senior guard-forward Emmanuel Smith scoring 14 of his hard-earned 20 points, Euclid closed to 31-29 late in the first half.

But Shaw, which held a 39-34 lead at halftime, got two quick baskets from Moore early in the third quarter and extended its advantage to 45-34 on a layup by junior forward Eddie Moseley off an assist from senior point guard B.J. Davis.

SHAW 75
EUCLID 73

"We kept climbing and climbing, but it was like there was grease at the top of the mountain," said Euclid coach Harold "Doc" Daugherty.

The Panthers (16-7) made their biggest climb in the fourth quarter. Trailing, 56-49, entering the final eight minutes, Euclid tied the score at 57 on a layup by senior forward Brandon Richardson with 6:12 left.

Shaw answered with two strong moves inside by Moseley, but the Panthers cut the deficit to 66-65 on a layup by sophomore forward Chris Harrell with just over three minutes remaining.

After a 3-pointer by junior guard Eugene Padgett gave the Red Ball Express a 71-67 lead, Euclid junior forward Johnny Moses and Shaw All-District senior forward Steve Chandler exchanged baskets.

The Panthers kept climbing back, tying the score at 73 on a driving one-hander down the lane by Smith and a jumper by Moses with 45 seconds left.

After calling a timeout with 19 seconds to go, Shaw got off a jump shot by Davis that missed the mark. However, in the battle for the rebound, the ball went out of bounds and possession was awarded to the Red Ball Express with seven seconds left.

Inbounding the ball under its basket, Shaw got it in Moore's hands and the 6-2 forward was fouled on a drive down the lane.

"I was nervous," said Moore, who stepped to the foul line with the Shaw faithful chanting "D.P., D.P." in honor of Parker. "But, after I hit the first one, I just knew the second one was going to come."

Euclid, a member of the LEL Lake Division, got off a long-range 3-point attempt by Smith in the final two seconds, but the ball hit the front of the rim and bounced away.

Carter leads Irish in race to victory

By E.L. ROGERS
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